



The right-wing governments of Germany and Italy backed the nationalists in the Spanish Civil War. Fascist parties continue to draw support to the present day.

SPANISH CIVIL WAR

In 1936, fighting began in Spain between the socialist and republican left and nationalists led by **General Franco 388–89** >>. A bitter civil war ensued which lasted until the nationalist victory in 1939. **Hitler 390–91** >> and Mussolini both sent military aid to support Franco while **Stalin 378–79** >> supported his opponents.



GENERAL FRANCO

NEOFASCISM

Political groups of the far right have continued to emerge since World War II. Some, termed Neo-Nazis, believe in reviving Hitler's national socialism. Neofascist groups share elements of Nazi beliefs and tend to concentrate on a nationalistic, anti-immigration stance. These groups have included *Alternativa Sociale* in Italy, led by Mussolini's granddaughter Alessandra; the French *Front National*, founded by Jean-Marie Le Pen; and Jörg Haider's Austrian Freedom Party.

Nuremberg Rally

In the 1930s the Nazis held annual rallies for the party faithful at Nuremberg, as in the picture above. Thousands of soldiers stand listening to Hitler speak.

of nation (see BEFORE), Nazism's goal was to unite all German-speaking people in a great German *Reich*, or empire (see p.393), that would last for a millennium. The Nazis believed races such as the Slavs and Jews were racially inferior to Aryans (white Caucasian people, the purest having blue eyes and blonde hair) and as such they would be banished from the *Reich*

to preserve Aryan racial purity. Later, the Jews were to be wiped out in the "Final Solution" (see pp.400–01).

Mass movements with fascist ideologies arose in many countries during the 1920s and 1930s. The Austrian government had fascist leanings well before the country was annexed by Germany (see pp.392–93). In Britain, the politician Oswald Mosley formed the British Union of Fascists. Mosley's "Blackshirts" acted as guards at political rallies and fought with left-wing and Jewish groups.



March on Rome

Mussolini's Blackshirts, shown above, were ordered to march on the Italian capital, Rome, in 1922. The Blackshirts, also called "*squadristi*" or squadrons, acted as paramilitary forces for the Fascist Party.

In 1918 the government of Germany's new Weimar Republic also faced huge problems. Germans were scarred by defeat in World War I and resentful of the peace settlements under which territory had been lost (see p.375). Economic troubles were made worse

by war reparation payments imposed on Germany by its victorious enemies. In 1919, an Austrian-born soldier, Adolf Hitler, joined a small Munich-based political group: The German Worker's Party. Hitler had ambitions for power. His tirades against capitalists, communists, and Jews (at whose

door he laid blame for all Germany's ills), would soon catch the public ear. His party was renamed the National Socialist German Workers Party (the NSDAP or Nazi Party, see pp.390–91).

Although the Nazi Party had much in common with Mussolini's Fascists, it also had a quasireligious element, with its all-powerful Führer who demanded submission and a zealous belief in the superiority of the German race. Taking up Hegel's idealist concept

"The truth is that men are tired of liberty."

BENITO MUSSOLINI, APRIL 7, 1923

ITALIAN LEADER (1883–1945)

BENITO MUSSOLINI

Mussolini rose to political prominence before World War I in the Italian Socialist Party. In 1915 he broke with the socialists over intervention in World War I and became a radical nationalist. In 1919 he founded the Blackshirts and the Italian Fascist Party in 1921. He became Prime Minister of Italy in 1922. Italy fought alongside Nazi Germany in World War II, and when the Allies invaded Italy in 1943, Mussolini was stripped of his powers, though he led a Social Republic in the north of the country until he was shot in April 1945.

